



Clinical: Pat Cummins' 2/16 set the stage for a nine-wicket knockout win against India in the 2012 edition.

But when Dhoni's men celebrated late into the Johannesburg night after pipping archrival Pakistan in a thrilling finale to break a 24-year World Cup drought, the format had the indelible seal of India's approval.

The carnival had produced moments that would feed into the lore of T20 cricket for eternity. Yuvraj Singh launching a hapless Stuart Broad into the Durban night sky for six sixes in an over, India beating Pakistan in a uniquely devised bowl-out to settle a tied game before shocking a power-packed Australian side in the semifinal, and finally Misbah-ul-Haq's ill-fated scoop landing in S. Sreesanth's hands made for reel-worthy snapshots even before the advent of social media carved its space in the shrinking attention economy. It was no surprise, thus, that less than a year later, the Indian Premier League (IPL) was formally launched, irrevocably



transforming the sport's landscape.

Though change is constant, progress is not. The IPL juggernaut rolled on and became the envy of the world, prompting some international stars to even give up national contracts to play a part in the two-month Indian cricket festival. However, India's trophy cabinet wore a barren look, with the Men in Blue failing to emulate the success of 2007 in seven subsequent iterations of the T20 World Cup.

The back-to-back failures in 2009 and 2010, when India exited unceremoniously without winning a single one of its six Super Eight games across both editions, would have prompted one to attribute the high of 2007 to beginner's luck. But it was a combination of factors that had led to the twin World Cup debacles. While other teams were undoubtedly catching up with the tempo of T20s, the Indians were also found wanting against the short ball on the pacy tracks **(left)** in England and the Caribbean. Moreover, India's then